

SHADOWS OF THE FORGOTTEN SHRINE

by Helm Evans



SHADOWS OF THE FORGOTTEN SHRINE

A D&D 5e Adventure for Levels 1–3

3–5 players · 3–4 sessions · 8–12 hours

THE SHATTERED VEIL

Book 1 of 5

by Helm Evans

TUCO ENTERPRISES · TUCO.ENTERPRISES

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ADVENTURE SUMMARY

A dark fantasy horror mystery for levels 1–3

SUMMARY

Three villagers have vanished from the farming community of Thornhaven, drawn into the ancient Blackwood Forest by whispered dreams and pale blue lights. The characters investigate the disappearances, navigate the unsettling forest, discover a forgotten shrine buried beneath centuries of growth, and must ultimately decide the fate of the entity sealed beneath it.

Can the seal be reinforced? Should it be destroyed? Or can the entity be banished entirely? The party's choices will determine the fate of Thornhaven — and the missing villagers.

ADVENTURE DETAILS

System	<i>D&D 5e</i>
Levels	<i>1–3</i>
Sessions	<i>3–4</i>
Players	<i>3–5</i>
Tone	<i>Horror mystery</i>
Play Time	<i>8–12 hours</i>

KEY THEMES

Atmosphere	<i>Creeping dread</i>
Focus	<i>Investigation</i>
Conflict	<i>Moral complexity</i>
Agency	<i>Multiple solutions</i>
Horror	<i>Environmental</i>
Endings	<i>Three outcomes</i>

BACKGROUND

Centuries ago, a cult known as the **Children of the Dark Radiance** performed a profane ritual at a forest shrine, attempting to tear a hole between worlds and summon the **Whispering Hollow** — a lesser void entity that feeds on despair and fear. The ritual was interrupted by a coalition of druids and clerics. In the ensuing battle, the entity was partially summoned and then sealed within the shrine itself, trapped but not destroyed. The shrine was buried and its location struck from all records.

In recent months, the seal has begun to weaken. The entity's whispers have grown louder, reaching out to vulnerable minds in nearby settlements. Three villagers — Elara, Thomas, and Sara — have been drawn into the forest by dreams and compulsions. They now serve as thralls, their life force slowly feeding the entity and further weakening the seal.

PACING NOTES

Session 1: Arrive in Thornhaven, investigate disappearances, gather clues, interact with villagers.

Session 2: Journey into the Blackwood, survive environmental hazards, discover the shrine.

Session 3: Explore the shrine's outer chambers, confront thralls, piece together the history.

Session 4: Descend to the Inner Sanctum, face the entity's manifestation, resolve the adventure.

ADVENTURE HOOKS

Four ways to draw the party to Thornhaven

HOOK 1: THE DESPERATE PLEA

Elder Miriam of Thornhaven approaches the party at a nearby town, offering payment (50 gp) and supplies in exchange for investigating the disappearances of three villagers. She is direct, frightened, and running out of options. *Best for: parties who respond to clear quests and monetary rewards.*

HOOK 2: PERSONAL CONNECTION

One player character has family ties to Thornhaven. They receive an urgent letter from a worried relative describing strange lights in the forest and villagers acting strangely before vanishing. *Best for: campaigns where PCs have established backstories and regional ties.*

HOOK 3: THE SURVIVOR

While traveling, the party encounters a young woman stumbling out of the Blackwood, muttering about "blue lights" and "voices in the stones." She is **Sara Greenfield**, one of the missing villagers, but she escaped before being fully corrupted. She can provide a partial description of the shrine. *Best for: immediate action and mystery.*

HOOK 4: HIRED INVESTIGATORS

A minor noble with interests in the region hires the party to investigate reports of unnatural phenomena near Thornhaven. Payment is generous, but the noble's motives may be more than purely altruistic. *Best for: morally complex campaigns with political undertones.*

DM NOTE

During Session 0 or at the table, have players briefly describe where they are when the adventure begins (marketplace, inn, riverbank, etc.). This creates natural starting positions and investment in Thornhaven.

TONE & THEMES

- Environmental Horror:** The Blackwood itself is unsettling — twisted trees, unnatural silence, the constant sense of being watched.
- Investigation over Combat:** Clues, NPC interactions, and environmental storytelling drive the narrative. Combat is a tool, not the solution.
- Moral Complexity:** The thralls were once innocent villagers. Can they be saved, or must they be stopped?
- Player Agency:** Multiple solutions exist for most challenges, rewarding creativity and roleplaying.

PART 1: THORNHAVEN

A village gripped by fear

DANGER ●○○○○



Thornhaven — a modest farming community of roughly 200 souls

VILLAGE DESCRIPTION

"The village of Thornhaven sits in a valley where the Thornbrook River meets the edge of the Blackwood Forest. Fields of barley and rye surround a cluster of thatched cottages. A low stone wall, more symbolic than defensive, marks the village boundary. But something is wrong — doors are barred, parents keep children indoors, and the tavern is nearly empty."

The mood has shifted dramatically over the past two weeks. What was once a welcoming, close-knit community is now gripped by fear. Three villagers have vanished, and no one knows why.

KEY LOCATIONS

Elder's Longhouse: Village hall and Miriam's residence. Contains family records dating back centuries.

The Temple: A modest shrine to the harvest pantheon, tended by Brother Aldric.

Garrett's Forge: The village blacksmith, recently abandoned by his daughter Elara.

Kessa's Hut: On the village outskirts, filled with drying herbs and animal tracks.

The Market Square: Central gathering space, now eerily quiet.

THE MISSING VILLAGERS

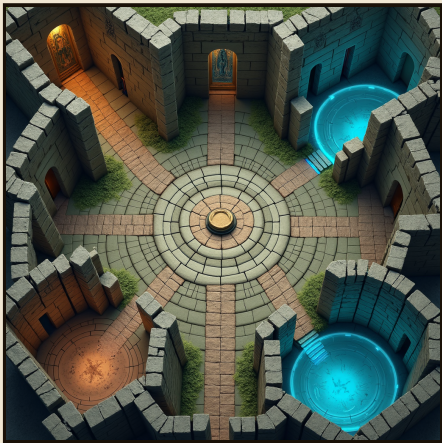
Three villagers have vanished over two weeks:

- ◆ **Elara Ironforge** (24) — Garrett's daughter, skilled apprentice smith, strong-willed and adventurous.
- ◆ **Thomas Fell** (31) — Quiet farmer, melancholic, recently lost his wife to illness.

PART 3: THE FORGOTTEN SHRINE

Beneath the Blackwood, the seal weakens

DANGER ●●●●○



The Forgotten Shrine — ancient stone halls beneath the forest

GENERAL FEATURES

- Light:** The runes provide dim light throughout the shrine. Darkness spells function normally.
- Ceilings:** 15 feet high in most chambers, 25 feet in the sanctum.
- Doors:** Heavy stone slabs requiring a DC 13 Strength check to open, or they can be wedged open with pitons or crowbars.
- Atmosphere:** The shrine radiates unease. Characters with darkvision notice shadows moving where nothing should be. Spellcasters feel a faint resistance when casting — not enough to prevent magic, but enough to be unsettling.

S1: ENTRANCE HALL

- A long, narrow hallway slopes downward, lined with alcoves containing skeletal remains. Each alcove holds the bones of a cultist who died during the original battle. The air is cold and still.
- Perception DC 12:** One skeleton in the third alcoid on the left is different — its skull is cracked, and faint necrotic energy still clings to the bones.
- Investigation DC 14:** A hidden compartment beneath that skeleton contains a *potion of healing* and a yellowed journal page describing the ritual that created the seal.
- Trap:** The fourth alcove on the right contains a pressure plate. If triggered, a portcullis slams down, dividing the party (DC 15 Strength to lift or DC 13 Thieves' Tools to bypass).

S2: HALL OF ECHOES

- A large, circular chamber with a high ceiling. The walls are covered in faded murals depicting a ritual — figures in dark robes gathered around a glowing pit, with a massive shadow rising behind them. Other figures — druids and clerics — stand opposed, hands raised in prayer.

